2026 FSI Veterans Hackathon — Starter Kits

Prepared October 9, 2026 · For the organizing team

How to use these kits

There is one kit per challenge. Each kit is everything a team needs to start building at 9:05 AM: the made-up veteran they are building for, and the sample documents their AI will read.

Everything here is fictional. The people, organizations, programs, phone numbers, addresses and amounts are invented for this event. The only real resource named is the Veterans Crisis Line (dial 988, then press 1), which teams should point to wherever someone may need professional help. Because it is all made up, teams can safely paste it into any AI tool on their personal accounts. Teams must not swap in real personal information.

Built-in puzzles. Each kit has a few things hidden on purpose, such as rules that contradict each other or a deadline mentioned in passing. That gives the AI something worth showing off. The last section, *Organizer answer keys*, lists them so judges know what to look for. **Delete that section before sharing the kits with teams.**

Handing them out

1. Have a veteran or someone from the Bob Woodruff Foundation or Cloud Veterans read each kit for realism. Edit anything that rings false.
2. Remove the answer keys.
3. Export each kit (Word or PDF) to a folder that opens from a personal laptop without a work sign-in, such as a view-only share link on a QR code at each table. Teams will copy the text into whatever AI tools they choose.
4. Print one copy of the team's kit for each table so people can mark it up.

Dates. All dates assume the story takes place on the event day, Thursday, November 5, 2026. Teams should treat that as "today."

Kit 01 — Roof and Runway

Sam's tool should read six messy program fact sheets and say, in plain English, which ones might help Sam and why.

1. Meet Sam Rivera (made up)

Age	34
Service	U.S. Army, 2012–2018, motor transport operator. Honorable discharge.
Lives in	Riverbend County, New Jersey (a made-up county)
Household	Sam and daughter Mia, age 7
Work	Warehouse associate, $22 an hour. Hours cut from 40 to 24 a week on August 20, 2026.
Rent	$1,650 a month. September and October unpaid ($3,300 behind). The lease is in Sam's name.
Today	An eviction notice was taped to the door on November 2.

What Sam says when asked "What's going on?" (use this as the typed or spoken input):

> "Honestly, I don't even know where to start. My hours got cut back in August, so I'm making maybe sixty percent of what I was. I'm two months behind on rent now and there was a notice on my door Monday. It's me and my daughter. I've called three places and every one of them says just apply to everything. I don't have time to fill out fifteen forms. I just need to know what's actually going to help, and fast."

Things Sam knows but didn't mention (only share these if the tool asks):

- Sam served on active duty for six years and has a DD-214 (discharge papers).
- There is a past-due electric bill of $410, but no shutoff notice yet.
- Sam does not know the date of the court hearing; the notice says one will be scheduled.
- Sam got $300 from a church food pantry's emergency fund in March 2026.

2. Riverbend County Emergency Rental Assistance (ERA)

Riverbend County Department of Human Services · Last updated September 15, 2026

The ERA program helps renter households in Riverbend County who are behind on rent and at risk of losing their housing.

Who can apply

- You rent your home in Riverbend County and your name is on the lease.
- You are behind on rent and have a written notice from your landlord or the court.
- Your household income for the past 12 months is at or below 50% of Area Median Income (see table).
- Applicants must first seek all other available sources of rental funding. ERA is the payer of last resort.

Household size	Maximum income (past 12 months)
1	$45,500
2	$52,000
3	$58,500
4	$65,000

What it pays. Up to 3 months of past-due rent, paid directly to the landlord.

How long it takes. Most applications are decided in 4 to 6 weeks. Incomplete applications take longer.

Documents. Lease, landlord notice, photo ID, proof of income for the past 12 months.

3. Tri-County Veterans Emergency Fund

Tri-County Veterans Alliance (a made-up nonprofit) · Last updated July 1, 2026

One-time grants for veterans facing a sudden financial crisis.

- Open to veterans who served at least 90 days on active duty and did not receive a dishonorable discharge.
- The crisis must have started within the last 90 days. Examples: job loss, reduced hours, medical emergency, car repair needed to keep a job.
- Grant of up to $1,500, paid directly to a landlord, utility or other vendor. We never pay cash to the applicant.
- Decisions within 3 business days; payment usually within 7 to 10 business days.
- Limit: one grant per household every 24 months.
- Bring: DD-214, photo ID and the bill or notice you need help with.

4. Riverbend Home Energy Assistance

Riverbend County Office of Energy Programs · Last updated October 1, 2026

Helps households pay overdue electric or gas bills.

- You must have an active shutoff notice from your utility company. Past-due bills without a shutoff notice are not eligible for crisis help, but you may apply for the regular seasonal benefit beginning December 1.
- Income limit: 60% of state median income. For a household of 2 that is $54,600 per year (current monthly income x 12).
- Crisis benefit: up to $700, paid to the utility within 48 hours of approval.
- Seasonal benefit: $250 to $600 credited to your account by mid-January.

5. Veteran Housing Stability Voucher (VHSV)

Made-up regional housing authority · Last updated May 20, 2026

A long-term rent subsidy for veterans who are homeless or about to become homeless. The voucher pays part of your rent every month, so you pay about 30% of your income.

- You must be a veteran with an other-than-dishonorable discharge.
- You must be homeless, or at imminent risk of homelessness. Imminent risk means you will lose your housing within 14 days and have nowhere else to go.
- Household income at or below 50% of Area Median Income.
- A case manager must refer you. We do not accept direct applications.
- Current wait time from referral to voucher: about 6 to 9 months.

6. St. Brendan's Community Fund

A made-up church-run neighborhood fund · Updated "Spring 2026"

We are a small volunteer fund helping our neighbors in Riverbend County with rent and utility emergencies.

- One gift per household in any 12-month period, up to $500.
- Our funds are limited. We do not assist households who are already receiving rental assistance from another program, so that our help reaches neighbors with nowhere else to turn.
- Volunteers meet Tuesday evenings. If approved, a check goes to your landlord within about a week.
- Call the parish office to make an appointment. Walk-ins are welcome when volunteers are available.

7. Workforce Transition Rent Bridge

Made-up state workforce program · Last updated August 4, 2026

Short-term rent help so newly separated service members can focus on finding civilian work.

- For veterans who separated from the military within the past 24 months.
- Must be enrolled in, or willing to enroll in, a job-training program.
- Pays up to 2 months of rent ($2,000 maximum), paid to the landlord within about 2 weeks.
- Statewide. Apply online or through any One-Stop Career Center.

Kit 02 — Money Moves

Chris's tool should explain a confusing pay stub or letter in plain language and suggest one small step for this week.

1. Meet Chris Ortiz (made up)

Age	29
Service	U.S. Army, 2018–2026, sergeant (E-5). Separated August 2026. Honorable discharge.
Lives in	Riverbend County, New Jersey (made up), renting a one-bedroom apartment
New job	Logistics coordinator, $68,000 a year, paid every two weeks. Started October 5, 2026.
Today	First full paycheck arrived October 30. A collections letter arrived November 3.

What Chris says when asked "What's going on?"

> "So my new job pays sixty-eight thousand a year, which is way more than my base pay was in the Army. I figured I'd be fine. But my first real paycheck was like seventeen hundred bucks. That can't be right. And then this letter shows up from some collections company about a phone bill. I thought I returned that phone when I moved. I don't even know which one to deal with first."

Things Chris knows but didn't mention (only share if asked):

- Chris has a store receipt showing the phone was returned on July 28, 2026.
- Chris has about $1,100 in savings.
- Chris has a credit card balance of $2,300 and pays only the minimum.

2. Chris's last military pay statement (text version)

Leave and Earnings Statement, monthly summary · Period: July 1–31, 2026 · All amounts made up

Entitlements	Amount	Taxed?
Base pay (E-5, over 6 years)	$3,850.00	Yes
Housing allowance (BAH)	$2,100.00	No
Food allowance (BAS)	$476.00	No
Total entitlements	**$6,426.00**	

Deductions	Amount
Federal income tax	$290.00
Social Security and Medicare (FICA)	$294.53
Life insurance (SGLI)	$31.00

Deductions	Amount
Retirement savings (TSP, 5% of base pay)	$192.50
Total deductions	**$808.03**

Net pay for the month: $5,617.97 (paid in two deposits of $2,808.98 and $2,808.99)

3. Chris's first civilian pay stub (text version)

Made-up employer: Harborline Distribution LLC · Pay period October 12–25, 2026 · Pay date October 30, 2026

Earnings	This period
Regular salary (80 hours)	$2,615.38

Deductions	This period
Federal income tax	$240.00
NJ state income tax	$95.00
Social Security	$162.15
Medicare	$37.92
Medical insurance (employee share)	$145.00
Dental insurance	$12.00
401(k) retirement (6%)	$156.92
Total deductions	**$848.99**

Net pay: $1,766.39. Paid every two weeks (26 paychecks a year).

4. Collections letter (text version)

> **Keystone Recovery Services** (a made-up debt collector)
> October 30, 2026
>
> Chris Ortiz
> 14 Linden Court, Apt 3B
> Riverbend, NJ
>
> Re: Fort Ridge Wireless account ending 4471
> Amount due: **$1,284.50**
>
> This is a communication from a debt collector. We are trying to collect a debt that you owe to Fort Ridge Wireless. We will use any information you give us to help collect the debt.
>
> Our records show you owed: $1,284.50 as of July 31, 2026. This includes: unreturned equipment fee, $899.00; early termination fee, $310.00; final month of service, $75.50.

> **How can you dispute the debt?** Call or write to us by **December 4, 2026** to dispute all or part of the debt. If you do not, we will assume our information is correct. If you write to us by December 4, 2026, we must stop collection until we send you information that shows you owe the debt.
>
> **Special offer:** Pay $899.00 by November 14, 2026 and we will consider this account settled in full.
>
> Call 1-800-555-0148, Monday to Friday, 9 AM to 6 PM.

5. Chris's monthly budget (made before starting the new job)

Item	Monthly amount
Expected take-home pay	$4,700
Rent	$1,450
Car payment	$385
Car insurance	$142
Groceries	$520
Gas	$180
Electric and internet	$160
Phone	$85
Credit card minimum payment	$75
Streaming services	$45
Gym	$40
Total spending	**$3,082**
Expected left over	**$1,618**

6. Free help nearby (all made up)

Name	What they do	How to reach them
Riverbend Credit Counseling	Free one-hour budget review with a certified counselor	Book online; appointments within 1 week
Veterans Legal Clinic at Riverbend Law School	Free help reading and responding to debt collection letters	Walk-in hours Wednesdays, 1 to 5 PM
Harborline employee assistance program	Free, confidential financial coaching for employees	Number on the back of Chris's benefits card
Transition Money Coaching (veteran volunteers)	Peer coaching for veterans in their first year out	Email intake; reply within 3 business days

Kit 03 — Someone Who Has Been There

Marcus's tool should read the six volunteer mentors' stories below and suggest the two who would truly understand him, with a reason he would nod at.

1. Meet Marcus Hale (made up)

Age	41
Service	U.S. Army, 2006–2025. Infantry, later a drill sergeant. Medically retired after 19 years because of a knee injury. Two deployments to Afghanistan.
Out since	September 2025 (fourteen months)
Lives in	Riverbend County, New Jersey (made up)
Family	Married, two teenage sons
Today	Has turned down three group programs. Doesn't want a counselor. A friend at church told him about the mentor program.

Marcus's story, in his own words (use as the input):

> "I was supposed to do twenty and walk out on my own terms. Instead my knee made the call for me at nineteen. Nobody tells you how quiet it gets. For nineteen years somebody needed something from me at 0500. Now I wake up at 0500 anyway and there's nothing to do. My wife's been patient but I can tell I'm wearing on her. The boys are teenagers, they've got their own lives.
>
> I tried one of those veteran groups. Twelve guys in a circle and a facilitator with a clipboard. Not for me. I don't want to talk about my feelings with strangers and I don't want a counselor. I'd just like to talk to somebody who's already been through the part where you stop being the guy everybody looks to and figure out who you are after that. One on one. Coffee, a walk, whatever. Somebody who won't make it a whole thing."

What Marcus is willing to share with a mentor (only use if the tool asks for his choices):

- Yes: branch, years served, that he was infantry and a drill sergeant, that he deployed, that he's adjusting to retirement.
- Yes: he wants one-on-one, not groups.
- No: anything about his marriage. He mentioned it in his story but doesn't want it passed on.
- No: his medical retirement details.

2. Mentor: Dave Kowalski (made up)

Army, 2004–2024, infantry, retired as a sergeant first class. Riverbend County.

> "Twenty years Army, infantry the whole way, retired in 2024. Honestly the transition was the easiest thing I ever did. I had my real estate license before I even got out, and I've been crushing it ever since. I tell every guy I mentor, the skills you learned are gold, you just have to hustle. I'd love to help other vets get into real estate, there's a lot of money in it. I'm available for one-on-ones most weekends."

3. Mentor: Ray Delgado (made up)

Marine Corps, 1999–2019, infantry, retired as a gunnery sergeant. Two counties over.

> "Twenty years in the Corps, grunt the whole time, two tours in Iraq and one in Afghanistan. Getting out was rough for me, I'm not going to lie. What helped was the group I run now, every Thursday night at the VFW hall. Brothers and sisters helping each other. I only mentor through the group, that's how I've found it works best. Strength in numbers."

4. Mentor: Linda Okafor (made up)

Air Force, 1994–2014, flight nurse, retired as a senior master sergeant. Riverbend County.

> "Twenty years as a flight nurse. I was in charge of people's lives at thirty thousand feet, and then one day I was home folding laundry. The first year was the hardest year of my life. Nobody called me 'Sarge' anymore. Nobody needed anything from me. I didn't sleep right for months, and I was short with my husband about things that didn't matter.
>
> What finally helped was one woman, a retired Army colonel, who'd meet me for coffee every Saturday and never once asked me how I was 'feeling.' We just talked. Eventually I built a woodshop in my garage. I mentor one person at a time. I'm not a counselor, I'm just somebody who's been where you are."

5. Mentor: Tyler Brooks (made up)

Navy, 2018–2022, electronics technician, separated as a petty officer second class. Riverbend County.

> "I did four years on a destroyer, then used my GI Bill for an engineering degree. I graduate in May. I mentor guys who are thinking about going back to school, help them figure out the GI Bill paperwork and which classes transfer. Happy to meet one-on-one at the campus coffee shop, evenings work best for me."

6. Mentor: James "Mac" McAllister (made up)

Army, 1997–2019, infantry then recruiting, retired as a first sergeant. Riverbend County.

> "Twenty-two years. Infantry, two trips to Afghanistan, ended up as a first sergeant and then a recruiter for my last three years. Retiring was a gut punch I didn't see coming. You go from a hundred and twenty soldiers needing you to nobody needing you overnight. Took me a good two years to figure out what I was for again.
>
> These days I coach high school wrestling and volunteer here. I'm not big on groups myself. One on one, early mornings are best since I'm still up at 0500 like an idiot."

7. Mentor: Denise Harper (made up)

Army National Guard, 2002–2017, supply sergeant. Riverbend County.

> "I served fifteen years in the Guard, including a deployment to Iraq. My husband was hurt badly on his own deployment, so for the last eight years I've mostly been his caregiver. I mentor other military spouses and caregivers. It's a whole world people don't see. I'm available weekday afternoons, one-on-one or by phone."

Kit 04 — Veterans Build America

Jordan's tool should turn a military training record into civilian skills, compare two trade careers, and land on one action for this week.

1. Meet Jordan Lee (made up)

Age	27
Service	U.S. Army, 2019–2026. Power-generation equipment repairer, then team leader. Leaves the Army on December 15, 2026. Honorable discharge expected.
Lives in	Riverbend County, New Jersey (made up)
Family	Single parent of a 3-year-old son
Has	A car, a high school diploma, about two months of savings

What Jordan says when asked "What are you looking for?"

> "I've fixed generators and power equipment for seven years. Diesel engines, electrical, all of it. I like working with my hands and figuring out why something's broken. I don't want a desk job. I'd love something where I can get paid while I learn a trade, like an apprenticeship. It has to be within about thirty miles of home, and it has to be daytime hours because of my son's daycare. I need to be earning by the end of January at the latest."

2. Jordan's military training record (text version)

Made-up record in the style of a Joint Services Transcript (JST). A JST is the official summary of a service member's military training and jobs. The college credit suggestions shown are made up.

Military jobs held

Dates	Job	Description
Mar 2019 – Jun 2022	Power-Generation Equipment Repairer	Inspects, troubleshoots and repairs diesel generators from 3 kW to 200 kW, including engines, fuel systems, cooling systems and electrical controls.
Jul 2022 – Dec 2026	Power-Generation Equipment Repairer, Team Leader	Leads a team of 4 repairers. Schedules preventive maintenance, inspects completed work, trains junior soldiers and keeps parts and tool records.

Military courses

Dates	Course	Suggested college credit (made up)
Jan–Mar 2019	Power-Generation Equipment Repairer Course, 13 weeks	3 credits basic electricity; 3 credits diesel engine repair; 2 credits blueprint reading
Sep 2020	Electrical Safety and Lockout/Tagout, 1 week	1 credit industrial safety

Dates	Course	Suggested college credit (made up)
Apr 2023	Basic Leader Course, 4 weeks	2 credits leadership; 1 credit communication

Other records

- Forklift operator license, issued May 2019, expired May 2022.
- Award citation, August 2024: "Diagnosed an intermittent control-panel fault on a 60 kW generator that two other teams could not find, restoring power to a field hospital within 6 hours."
- Supervisor evaluation, 2025: "Keeps detailed maintenance logs. Trained four new soldiers on generator troubleshooting."

3. Career path A: HVAC technician apprentice (made-up program)

Northern NJ Mechanical Trades Apprenticeship · Information sheet updated September 2026

- **What it is.** A 4-year paid apprenticeship installing and repairing heating, air conditioning and refrigeration systems. Classes two evenings a week; the rest is paid work with a mentor.
- **Pay.** Starts at $22 an hour, rising each year to about $36 an hour by year four.
- **Hours.** Day shift, Monday to Friday, about 7 AM to 3:30 PM. Some emergency calls in summer.
- **Requirements to start.** High school diploma or GED; valid driver's license; pass a basic math test.
- **Requirements during the program.** EPA Section 608 certification (needed to handle refrigerants) within the first 6 months. Apprentices pay a $150 exam fee.
- **Next class starts.** January 18, 2027. Applications close December 10, 2026.
- **Veterans.** Military experience in electrical or mechanical work may count toward up to 6 months of the apprenticeship.

4. Career path B: Industrial maintenance technician (made-up summary)

Career guide for northern New Jersey manufacturers · Updated June 2026

- **What it is.** Keeping factory machines running: troubleshooting electrical, mechanical and hydraulic problems, plus preventive maintenance.
- **Pay.** Typically $25 to $32 an hour to start in this region.
- **Hours.** Most plants run 24 hours a day. New technicians usually start on second or third shift.
- **Requirements.** Usually 2 or more years of hands-on mechanical or electrical troubleshooting. Experience with programmable logic controllers (PLCs, the small computers that control factory machines) is often preferred.
- **Training.** Mostly on the job. Some employers pay for extra certifications.

5. Sample job opening (made up)

> **Industrial Maintenance Technician I** — Pinebrook Foods, Riverbend plant (18 miles from Jordan)
> Posted October 20, 2026 · Applications close November 20, 2026
>
> **Pay:** $27 an hour, plus a $1.50 an hour shift bonus.
> **Shift:** Second shift, 3:00 PM to 11:30 PM, Monday to Friday.

> **Must have:** 2 years of mechanical or electrical maintenance experience. Ability to follow lockout/tagout safety rules.
> **Nice to have:** PLC experience. Forklift license.
> **Start date:** January 4, 2027.
> We welcome veterans and offer tuition help after 90 days.

Kit 05 — The Last Mile

The case worker's tool should read these notes, find the urgent problem that was only mentioned in passing, and put it on a timeline.

The notes are written the way busy case workers really write: shorthand, abbreviations, no headings. All four come from the same made-up organization, the Riverbend Veterans Resource Center. "Today" is Thursday, November 5, 2026.

1. Case note: Ruth Calloway (main scenario)

> **Client:** Ruth Calloway, 63, USN vet (1981–1985, yeoman). Lives alone, Millbrook Twp (rural, north end of county).
> **Date:** 11/5/26 · **Case worker:** T. Nguyen
>
> Walk-in for food box. Got a ride in from neighbor, neighbor waited in lot. Pleasant, a little anxious, said she hates asking for help. Gave standard box + produce. Pantry card updated.
>
> Asked about other needs, she said she's "managing." SS is her only income (~$1,340/mo). Mentioned landlord "has been on her" since the rent went up in Sept and she paid partial for Oct. Said there's "some court thing on the 16th" but landlord told her they'd probably work it out. Didn't have paperwork with her.
>
> Car has been sitting since summer, said license got suspended over unpaid tickets from "forever ago" and she can't afford to fix it anyway. Neighbor drives her when he can. Missed a VA eye appt in Oct bc no ride.
>
> SNAP recert letter came, due end of month, she has it at home.
> Follow up: ?

2. Case note: Earl Simmons

> **Client:** Earl Simmons, 52, Army vet. Riverbend city.
> **Date:** 11/3/26 · **Case worker:** T. Nguyen
>
> Called in, wants help w/ job search. Laid off from auto parts store in Sept. Has a lead on a warehouse job in Eastfield, interview was set for 10/28 but he had to reschedule, then missed the reschedule too. Also behind on a VA disability exam, missed 2 appts. Says "stuff keeps coming up." When asked, said his truck's transmission went out in Sept and the bus doesn't go out to Eastfield or the VA clinic. Asked about job training programs. Gave him the list of hiring events.

3. Case note: Angela Ruiz

> **Client:** Angela Ruiz, 38, Air Force vet. Riverbend city, 2 kids.
> **Date:** 11/4/26 · **Case worker:** M. Patel
>
> Came in for winter coats for the kids, gave 2 coats from the closet. Working full time at the hospital, housing is stable, no other needs today. Very nice, said she wants to volunteer at the coat drive next month. Gave her the volunteer form.

4. Case note: Frank Dooley

> **Client:** Frank Dooley, 71, Army vet (Vietnam era). Westbrook.
> **Date:** 11/2/26 · **Case worker:** M. Patel
>
> Daughter called on his behalf. Frank got a letter from the county about his property taxes being behind, daughter thinks there's a hearing "on the 3rd" but isn't sure which month, letter is at his house. Frank is a widower, daughter lives in PA. Asked if we know anyone who helps w/ property tax relief for seniors or vets. Told her I'd look into it.

5. Local services (all made up)

Millbrook Legal Aid Clinic *Availability last updated November 1, 2026*

- Free legal help for low-income residents of the county, including tenants facing eviction and people with license suspensions.
- Currently accepting new eviction cases. Next open intake appointments: Monday, November 9 and Tuesday, November 10.
- Appointments are in person in Riverbend city or **by phone**.
- Bring or send: any court papers, the lease and any letters from the landlord.
- Referrals from case workers are welcome by email with the client's permission.

Riverbend Vets Ride *Availability last updated October 28, 2026*

- Free rides for veterans to medical appointments, court dates and job interviews anywhere in the county.
- Book at least 3 business days ahead.
- November is fully booked. New requests go on a waitlist. December bookings open November 15.

Millbrook Community Food Pantry *Availability last updated October 15, 2026*

- Open Tuesdays and Saturdays, 10 AM to 1 PM, at the Millbrook Fire Hall.
- A mobile pantry truck visits the north end of the township on the second Saturday of each month (next visit: November 14).
- Can help with SNAP applications and renewals on Tuesdays.

Kit 06 — Veteran Stability Navigator

Alex's tool should turn one telling of Alex's story into a short summary Alex approves, then pick a main organization and a backup from the list below.

1. Meet Alex Morgan (made up)

Age	36
Service	U.S. Navy, 2008–2014, aviation electronics technician. Honorable discharge.
Lives in	Riverbend city, New Jersey (made up), near the Route 4 bus line
Family	Two children, ages 9 and 12
Work	Customer service representative until October 16, 2026, when the call center closed
Rent	$1,500 a month. October paid; November unpaid.
Transportation	Shares a car with a sister; only available on weekends. Otherwise takes the bus.

Alex's story, in Alex's own words (use as the input):

> "I've told this story so many times this month I could do it in my sleep. The call center I worked at closed in October, no warning. I've got unemployment coming but it's not enough to cover rent, and November's already late. I've got two kids, 9 and 12. I've been eating less so they don't have to, but that can't last.
>
> Every place I call wants me to come in, fill out the same forms, tell the same story. I don't have a car during the week, so getting across the county is a whole day. I just want to tell it once, to one place that can actually help, and not have my whole life sent everywhere. And I need a job, a real one. I fixed avionics in the Navy, I'm not just a phone person."

Things Alex knows but didn't mention (only share if asked):

- The landlord has not sent a notice yet, but said "we need to talk" if rent isn't paid by November 15.
- Alex has not applied for food help (SNAP) before.
- Alex is fine sharing: name, phone, veteran status, household size, rent amount and that rent is late, job loss date.
- Alex does not want shared: the kids' names or ages, or the detail about skipping meals, unless Alex says so.

2. Local organizations (all made up)

Riverbend Veterans Resource Center *Availability last updated November 2, 2026*

- One-stop help for veterans: a case worker, emergency rent and utility grants (up to $1,500), food pantry referrals, and job search help.
- Location: downtown Riverbend city, two blocks from a Route 4 bus stop.
- Hours: Monday to Friday, 9 AM to 5 PM.
- Accepts referrals through a secure online form. A case worker calls back within 2 business days.

- Currently accepting new clients.

Eastfield Family Services *Availability last updated October 20, 2026*

- Emergency rent help for families with children (up to $1,000), plus a weekly food pantry and SNAP application help.
- Location: Eastfield, about 40 minutes by car. Not on a bus line.
- Phone intake appointments available, but the current wait is about 2 weeks.
- Serves all residents of the county, veterans or not.

Northside Veterans Housing Collaborative *Availability last updated September 30, 2026*

- Helps veterans who are currently homeless find permanent housing.
- Does not provide help with past-due rent for veterans who still have housing.
- Location: north Riverbend city, on the Route 2 bus line.

Riverbend Workforce Center *Availability last updated November 3, 2026*

- Free job search help, resume reviews and paid training programs, including electronics technician training.
- Veterans get priority for training seats.
- No help with rent or food.
- Location: downtown Riverbend city, on the Route 4 bus line. Walk-ins welcome Monday to Thursday.

3. Referral status steps (for the bonus round)

If a team shows referral tracking, these are the steps a referral moves through:

1. Draft: Alex is still reviewing the summary.
2. Approved: Alex has picked exactly what to share.
3. Sent: the referral went to the organization.
4. Received: the organization confirmed they got it.
5. Follow-up due: no call within 2 business days, so someone checks in, or the backup organization is used.

Organizer answer keys

Delete this section before sharing the kits with teams. It lists what a good tool should notice in each kit, so judges and mentors know what to look for. Teams don't need to find everything: the must-haves come first.

Kit 01 — Roof and Runway

Program	Result for Sam	Why
Tri-County Veterans Emergency Fund	**Eligible.** Fastest money: 7–10 business days.	Six years of active duty, honorable discharge. Hours were cut August 20, which is 77 days before the event, inside the 90-day window.
St. Brendan's Community Fund	**Unknown.** About 1 week if eligible.	Sam got $300 from "a church food pantry" in March. If that was St. Brendan's, Sam can't get help again until March 2027. The tool should ask, not guess.
Riverbend Emergency Rental Assistance	**Likely eligible.** 4–6 weeks.	Lease in Sam's name and a written notice. Past-12-month income is about $41,900, under the $52,000 limit for 2 people.
Riverbend Home Energy Assistance	**Not eligible for crisis help yet.**	No shutoff notice. Sam can apply for the seasonal benefit from December 1.
Veteran Housing Stability Voucher	**Unknown, and slow.**	Only applies if Sam will lose housing within 14 days; the hearing date isn't known. Needs a case manager referral and takes 6–9 months.
Workforce Transition Rent Bridge	**Not eligible.**	Sam left the Army in 2018, more than 24 months ago. A good "not eligible, and here's why" example.

The contradiction. Emergency Rental Assistance says to try every other source first. St. Brendan's won't help anyone already getting rental assistance from another program. A good tool notices that the order matters and says so.

Other things to notice

- Programs measure income differently: "past 12 months" versus "current monthly income x 12". Sam's answer changes depending on which is used.
- St. Brendan's says only "Spring 2026". A good tool flags undated information as possibly out of date.
- Good questions to ask Sam: "Was the $300 in March from St. Brendan's?", "Do you know your court date?", "Has the electric company sent a shutoff notice?"

Kit 02 — Money Moves

The paycheck isn't wrong.

- In the Army, $2,576 a month of Chris's pay was tax-free housing and food allowances.

- The $68,000 salary is fully taxed, and there are new deductions for state tax, health and dental insurance, and a 401(k).
- $1,766.39 every two weeks works out to about $3,827 a month. That is about $1,790 less than Chris's Army take-home, and $873 less than the $4,700 Chris budgeted.
- The good news: at $3,827 a month, Chris still has about $745 left over after the planned spending.
- Twice a year Chris will get three paychecks in one month.

The letter.

- Two dates matter: the $899 settlement offer ends November 14, and the deadline to dispute is December 4.
- Chris has a receipt showing the phone was returned on July 28, which relates to the $899 equipment fee.
- A good tool explains what the letter says and points Chris to the free legal clinic, bringing the letter and the receipt.
- It should not tell Chris whether to pay or whether the debt is owed. That is legal advice.

Watch for:

- The clinic's walk-in day is Wednesday, and the next Wednesday is November 11, Veterans Day. A careful tool suggests checking that the clinic is open that day.
- No investment or tax advice, such as "stop your 401(k)".

Kit 03 — Someone Who Has Been There

Mentor	Fit	Why
Mac McAllister	**Strong match**	Army infantry, 22 years, Afghanistan. Lost the sense of "being needed". Prefers one-on-one, early mornings, still up at 0500. Honest difference: Mac retired on his own terms; Marcus didn't.
Linda Okafor	**The unlikely but right match**	Different branch, job, gender and era. But she describes the same quiet, the same loss of being "Sarge", strain at home, and a mentor who never asked about feelings. One-on-one only.
Dave Kowalski	Looks perfect on paper, wrong in reality	Same branch, job and era. But his transition was "the easiest thing", and he is recruiting people into real estate.
Ray Delgado	Looks close on paper, wrong in reality	Similar infantry career, but he only mentors through a group. Marcus has turned down groups three times.
Tyler Brooks	Not a fit	Four years in, focused on college and the GI Bill.
Denise Harper	Not a fit	Focused on caregivers and military spouses.

Privacy test. Marcus said no to sharing anything about his marriage or medical retirement. The match reason the mentor sees must not mention either, even though the Linda match touches on strain at home.

Kit 04 — Veterans Build America

Skills the record supports, with the line each came from

- Diesel engine and generator troubleshooting and repair: job description and 2019 course.
- Electrical controls and basic electricity: 2019 course and the 2024 award (control-panel fault).
- Lockout/tagout safety: 2020 course. This matches a "must have" in the Pinebrook job.
- Planning preventive maintenance and keeping records: team leader duties and 2025 evaluation.
- Training and leading others: team leader duties, 2023 course and 2025 evaluation.

Traps

- **The forklift license is out of date.** It expired in May 2022, so it should be shown as stale, not as a current skill.
- **No PLC experience.** It is not in the record. A tool should not assume it from "electrical controls".
- **Refrigeration is a guess.** Generator cooling systems are not air conditioning. Any claim about refrigeration skills should be marked as inferred and checked with Jordan.
- **EPA 608 certification** is missing, but it can be earned during the HVAC apprenticeship.

The key trade-off

	HVAC apprenticeship	Pinebrook Foods job
Pay to start	$22 an hour	$28.50 an hour with the shift bonus
Hours	Day shift, fits daycare	**Second shift (3 to 11:30 PM), conflicts with daycare**
Start date	January 18, 2027	January 4, 2027
Apply by	December 10, 2026	November 20, 2026
Learn a trade while paid	Yes	Mostly on the job

A good tool shows this trade-off and lets Jordan choose. Either of these is a sensible action for this week:

- Apply to the apprenticeship, and ask whether military experience counts toward the program.
- Ask Pinebrook whether a day shift is possible.

Kit 05 — The Last Mile

Ruth's timeline (what a good tool builds)

Date	What	Source sentence
Nov 9 or 10	Legal aid intake appointments, **by phone** (solves the no-ride problem)	Clinic listing

Date	What	Source sentence
Nov 14	Mobile food pantry visits the north end of the township	Pantry listing
Nov 16 (Monday)	**Probable eviction court hearing.** Needs confirming: Ruth had no paperwork.	"Said there's 'some court thing on the 16th'"
Nov 30	SNAP renewal due. The pantry helps with renewals on Tuesdays.	"SNAP recert letter came, due end of month"

Ruth: other things to notice

- Her license suspension is a legal issue the same clinic handles.
- She missed a VA appointment because she had no ride.
- Vets Ride is fully booked for November. The backup is a phone appointment with the legal clinic, plus asking her neighbor about the 16th or joining the waitlist (December bookings open November 15).

The other notes

- **Earl:** transportation is the hidden blocker. His broken truck explains the missed interview and missed VA exams, but the case worker only gave him a list of hiring events.
- **Angela:** nothing hidden. A good tool does not invent problems. This note tests that.
- **Frank:** the hearing "on the 3rd" has no month. The tool must flag it as uncertain, not guess December 3. No service in the kit handles property tax relief, so the tool should say "no match" rather than force one.

Kit 06 — Veteran Stability Navigator

Organization	Role	Why
Riverbend Veterans Resource Center	**Main choice**	Rent grants up to $1,500, which covers November. Also food referrals and job help. On Alex's bus line, open weekdays, accepting clients, calls back in 2 business days.
Eastfield Family Services	**Backup**	Helps families with children with rent (up to $1,000), food and SNAP. Phone intake avoids the transport problem, but the 2-week wait is close to the landlord's November 15 deadline.
Riverbend Workforce Center	A good second step, not a rent fix	Electronics technician training fits "I fixed avionics". No rent help.
Northside Veterans Housing Collaborative	**Not a fit**	Only serves veterans who are already homeless.

The unstated need. Alex says "I've been eating less so they don't have to" but never asks for food help. A good tool gently asks whether Alex wants food assistance or SNAP help.

The privacy test. Alex agreed to share household size, but not the children's names or ages, or the detail about skipping meals. If Alex wants food help, the referral can say that without the skipped-meals detail.

The date. November 15 is the landlord's "we need to talk" date, not an eviction notice. A good tool doesn't overstate it.